AI Image & Video Generation

Becoming an AI Director: tools, prompting & production workflows — comprehensive session notes

Generative AI Mastermind · Outskill

⏱ **Session:** AI Image & Video Generation — from prompting frameworks to a full commercial production workflow

✎ **What's inside:** The model landscape (updated June 2026), image & video prompting frameworks, credit-saving strategies, aggregators, and an end-to-end ad production walkthrough

✦ **How to use:** Skim once end-to-end, pick one image tool and one video tool, and produce your first 10-second clip this week

1. The AI-First Creative Landscape

The economic reality driving adoption of AI image and video tools is simple: in 2026, companies are tightening budgets and asking why they should pay an agency thousands of dollars when an ad can be produced for under $50. The takeaway is stark — **you are either being replaced by AI, or you are running the AI.** This session is about becoming the person who runs it: the AI Director.

1.1 The timeline of generative visual AI

- **2022 — The ChatGPT moment.** LLMs become a household word overnight.
- **2023 — AI images take off.** Midjourney gains mass adoption as the first major AI image generator.
- **2024 — AI video arrives.** Runway leads as one of the first major video generation tools.
- **2025 — The AI Director era.** Creators begin using multi-tool workflows to produce full AI films and commercial content; integrated sound arrives in video models.
- **2026 — Production-ready.** Native 4K output, synchronized dialogue, multi-shot sequences and sub-$50 ad production become reality.

2. The Model Landscape

A central theme of the session: **there is no single "best" model for everything.** Different models excel at different use cases. The right approach is to maintain a small personal toolkit of favourites.

> **The camera analogy**
>
> Think of AI diffusion models as the new cameras. In the physical world, a filmmaker picks a few favourites — a Canon, a Sony, an iPhone, a drone, a GoPro — and sticks with them, without worrying about every camera brand in existence. Same with AI models: **pick a few, learn them well**, and add new ones only when they offer something your current stack can't do.

2.1 Top AI image models (updated June 2026)

Model	Company	Notes
GPT Image 2 / 1.5	OpenAI	GPT Image 2 currently tops the blind-vote arenas; the family is excellent for text-in-images and precise, instruction-following edits

Model	Company	Notes
Nano Banana Pro (Gemini 3 Pro Image)	Google	A favourite of many pros — top-tier quality and photorealism, slower and pricier per generation
Nano Banana 2	Google	Fast and cheap, with a generous free tier on Gemini — best for high-volume generation
Seedream 4.5	ByteDance	Strong quality at very low credit cost — ideal for testing prompts before switching to a premium model
Flux 2 (Pro / Max)	Black Forest Labs	The leading open-weight family; cost-effective, can be run locally and fine-tuned on your own data
Midjourney (v7/v8)	Midjourney	Famous for its dreamy, artistic aesthetic; closed source, accessible only via its own platform
Hunyuan Image 3.0	Tencent	A specialist pick for anime and stylised character art
Krea 1	Krea AI	Krea's own model — and the platform also aggregates most of the models above in one interface

2.2 Top AI video models (updated June 2026)

Model	Company	Notes
Seedance 2.0	ByteDance	Currently #1 on the Artificial Analysis with-audio leaderboard; multi-shot storytelling with synchronized audio from a single generation
Kling 3.0 / v3	Kuaishou	A top overall pick: native 4K at 60fps, 15-second clips, integrated sound with multilingual lip-sync, start/end frames, camera presets
Veo 3.1	Google	Best-in-class native audio — the only model generating 48kHz synchronized dialogue; strong scene consistency
HappyHorse-1.0	Alibaba	The newest leaderboard climber (April 2026) — joint audio-video generation with lip-sync in seven languages

Model	Company	Notes
Runway Gen-4.5	Runway	The original pioneer; no longer top of the leaderboard but still the best control surface (motion brushes, scene consistency) — the pro-workflow choice
Hailuo 2.3	MiniMax	Great for wide landscape shots and motion physics
Grok Imagine	xAI	Newer entrant — already competitive from its first full release
Wan 2.6	Alibaba	The leading open-source video option — can be run on your own hardware
PixVerse V4.5	PixVerse	Strong contender; a specialist for anime and stylised video content

⚠ This space moves monthly. OpenAI's Sora 2, a 2025 leader, is being discontinued through 2026 — a reminder not to build your whole workflow on a single model. Always check the live leaderboard (§2.4) before committing.

> **The Seedance controversy — and the one hard rule**
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> ByteDance's Seedance 2.0 is so high-quality that it unsettled both Hollywood and AI filmmakers: it can produce multi-shot short films from a single prompt, and a viral fight scene between two A-list Hollywood actors forced ByteDance to restrict image-to-video prompting over copyright and likeness concerns.
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> ✔ **Key rule: never use someone's image or likeness without their consent.**

2.3 Integrated sound — the breakthrough

Until recently, creators had to lip-sync audio separately — a time-consuming and expensive step. Models like **Veo 3.1**, **Kling 3.0** and **Seedance 2.0** now generate audio natively with the video — dialogue, ambient sound and music in a single generation — dramatically accelerating the production workflow.

2.4 The Artificial Analysis leaderboard

artificialanalysis.ai is the industry-standard benchmarking site. It shows two anonymous images or videos side by side and lets users vote on which they prefer; rankings update continuously from this crowd-sourced voting. It covers AI images, video, audio and LLMs. Check it whenever you're choosing a model — the rankings reshuffle every few months.

3. The Image Prompting Framework

Image prompting is fundamentally different from video prompting. For images, you separate each element with commas and use keywords rather than full sentences. Think like a creative director on a physical set: what elements are in your scene?

3.1 The prompt elements

Element	What to specify
Subject	Who or what is the main focus — e.g. "a man sleeping in bed"
Action	What the subject is doing — e.g. "reaching for the alarm clock"
Environment	The setting — e.g. "ultra-modern bedroom, early morning"
Atmosphere / feel	Mood and tone — e.g. "cinematic style, dramatic lighting"
Camera	Changes the entire look: "shot on iPhone" = casual mobile feel; "shot on ARRI Alexa" or "RED" = Hollywood-grade cinematic look
Lens (optional)	Focal length (100mm for extreme close-up, 15–20mm wide angle) or lens brands (Zeiss, G lens)
Lighting	Natural, studio, bioluminescent, tungsten, golden hour — dramatically affects the image
Style reference	Upload a screenshot from a film with the look you want and ask the model to replicate that visual style

> **The priority rule**
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> Whatever you place **closer to the front of your prompt gets more emphasis** in the output. If the alarm clock is the focal point, put "alarm clock on nightstand showing 6 AM" before "man sleeping in bed". If the subject should dominate, lead with the subject.

Practice image prompt (comma-separated keywords)

✔ **Prompt:**

"Alarm clock on a nightstand showing 6 AM, a man sleeping in bed, sports-car painting above the bed, side angle shot, ultra-modern bedroom, early morning, ultra-realistic, cinematic style."

3.2 Camera angle cheat sheet

- **Dutch angle** — tilted, chaotic feel (horror, tension)
- **Low angle** — looking up; makes the subject feel powerful (the "power shot")
- **Cowboy shot** — torso up, classic framing
- **100mm lens** — extreme close-up, tight on the subject
- **15–20mm lens** — wide shot, great for real estate and landscapes
- **Leading lines composition** — lines in the scene draw the eye to a focal point

Critical keyword: "ultra-realistic"

✘ Without explicit style instructions, the model may output a cartoon, a 3D render, or a random aesthetic.

✔ **Always include:** *"ultra-realistic, cinematic style"* for professional, photorealistic results.

3.3 Editing images instead of regenerating

Modern image models support iterative editing — upload an image and describe the change, rather than regenerating the whole scene from scratch:

Practice editing prompts

✔ **Prompt 1:**

"Remove the blinds at the back of the room."

✔ **Prompt 2:**

"Add a stainless steel coffee machine on the kitchen island."

4. Video Prompting

Video prompting is quite different: instead of comma-separated keywords, you **describe the scene in natural language using full sentences**, because video models need to understand motion, timing and narrative sequence.

> **Practice video prompt (natural language)**
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> **✔ Prompt:**
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> *"The man walks into the kitchen from the hallway on the right. He is dead tired and walking very slowly. After he turns the corner, he stumbles and falls to his knees, then quickly gets back up and continues walking to the coffee machine."*

4.1 Image-to-video, not text-to-video

Professionals use **image-to-video** prompting. With text-to-video you're playing a slot machine — a random output with no visual anchor. With image-to-video, you upload a reference image that serves as the **first frame**, giving the model a concrete starting point. This produces vastly more controlled and consistent results.

4.2 Start frame and end frame

An even more powerful technique: provide both a **start frame** and an **end frame**, and the model creates the transition between them. Example — start frame: a man in pyjamas looking tired, holding coffee. End frame: the same man in a suit, smiling, ready for work. The model generates the transformation in between.

4.3 Camera movement presets & timing

Tools like Kling offer camera presets you can apply with a click (or type into the prompt):

- **Handheld device filming** — realistic, slightly shaky feel, as if someone is physically there with a camera
- **Camera zooms in** — great for drawing attention to a subject or moment
- **Camera zooms out** — ideal for ending shots, pulling away to reveal context
- **Speed control** — specify slow or fast camera motion

You can also add timestamps in your prompt (e.g. *"3 seconds in, he stumbles"*) to control when specific actions occur — though models don't always follow timing precisely.

5. Cost, Credits & Pricing Strategy

Time to debunk the "free tier fantasy" — and learn to spend credits like a professional.

5.1 The free tier: what it really gets you

- Free trials exist on Kling, Krea, Hailuo and Higgsfield — but they come with **watermarks, limited generations and longer queue times**.
- Google's **Nano Banana 2** is a landmark exception: available with a generous free tier on Gemini — the best free option for high-volume image generation.
- ⚠ Free accounts typically do **not** grant copyright ownership of generated content.

5.2 The professional budget

For serious content creation, expect to spend roughly **$30–50 per month across 2–3 platforms**. This gets you clean exports (no watermarks), high-quality outputs up to native 4K, faster queues and full features. Costs escalate quickly when producing short films or high volumes of client ads — which is why credit discipline matters.

5.3 Credit-saving strategies

- **Start at the lowest resolution** (720p for video, 1K for images). Only upgrade to 1080p/4K once you're happy with the prompt — a wrong take at 720p costs a fraction of the same mistake at 1080p.
- **Generate one output at a time** when testing. Multiple simultaneous variations burn credits you may not need.
- **Use cheaper models for testing.** On an aggregator, a Seedream generation can cost ~6 credits versus ~100 for Nano Banana Pro. Validate the prompt on the cheap model, then switch to the premium model for the final.
- **Plan everything before generating.** Write your full scene breakdown and storyboard before burning a single credit.
- **Combine free trials across platforms** (Hailuo, Higgsfield, Krea) to extend your free usage while learning.
- **Crop watermarks** by slightly expanding your video frame so the watermark falls outside the visible area.

> ⚠ **Copyright considerations**
>
> Copyright policies vary by platform and pricing tier. In many cases **free-tier users do not own the rights** to their generated content, while paid users do. Review each platform's specific terms before using generated content commercially.

6. Aggregator Platforms

The biggest cost concern — subscriptions to many models — is solved by **aggregator platforms** that bundle dozens of models into one subscription. Inside Krea, for example, you can access models from Google (Nano Banana Pro, Nano Banana 2), ByteDance (Seedream), Alibaba (Qwen), Black Forest Labs (Flux) and OpenAI (GPT Image) — all from a single interface, switching models with one click.

Pay-per-use aggregators	Monthly subscription aggregators
FAL, Replicate	**Freepik, Krea**
Cheaper per generation	More expensive overall
Less user-friendly, developer-style interfaces	Beautiful, pleasant UX
Best for: high-volume users who want to minimise cost	Best for: most users who want ease of use and a smooth creative experience

For most people the monthly subscription aggregators win despite the higher cost, because the creative experience is significantly better.

6.1 Open source vs. closed source

Open source models (Flux, Wan, Stable Diffusion) can be downloaded and run locally on your own hardware, and trained with custom data. **Closed source models** (like Midjourney) can only be accessed through their own platforms, with no API or local access. *Think Mac vs. Windows: Mac is closed and curated; Windows is open and customisable.*

7. Worked Example: Producing a Coffee Commercial

The second half of the session was a hands-on, end-to-end production of a complete coffee commercial using a multi-tool workflow. Use the same recipe for your own first ad.

7.1 The storyboard

The ad concept: a man wakes up, stumbles into the kitchen like a zombie, makes coffee, takes a sip, gets struck by a supernatural lightning-whirlwind effect, and is instantly transformed — wearing a suit, hair slicked back, ready for work. Tagline: *"That is the best coffee I've ever had."*

Step 1 — Generate reference images (Krea)

All reference images were generated in Krea, starting with the bedroom scene using the comma-separated framework from §3. A cheap model (Seedream, ~6 credits) was used to validate the prompt, then the same prompt was re-run on a premium model (Nano Banana Pro, ~100 credits) for an immediate, dramatic quality jump. Individual images were then refined with editing prompts ("remove the blinds…", "add a stainless steel coffee machine…") instead of regenerating from scratch.

Step 2 — Character consistency

To keep the same character across all scenes, upload the **same headshot as an image reference in every prompt** — the model recognises "the man" from the reference and applies the likeness (use your own photo, or one you have consent to use). Two discipline rules:

- Specify clothing **explicitly** ("white t-shirt", not just "white shirt").
- Keep wardrobe descriptions **identical across every prompt** in a scene to avoid continuity errors.

Step 3 — Generate video clips (Kling)

Each shot was produced with the **image-to-video** technique: upload a start frame (and sometimes an end frame), then describe the scene in natural language. The iterative reality of professional AI production, as it happened:

- **First attempt:** the character entered the kitchen from the wrong side (through the window). Cost: 60 credits at 720p.
- **The fix:** adding *"from the hallway on the right"* to the prompt and regenerating — exactly why you test at low resolution first.
- **Camera presets:** *"camera zooms in, slow"* for the alarm-clock wake-up shot.
- **Integrated sound:** Kling 3.0 generated audio natively along with the video.

Step 4 — Post-production

All clips were assembled in editing software — Adobe Premiere Pro, with **CapCut as an excellent free alternative**. Shots were produced *out of order*, which is normal in any production workflow: you shoot in whatever order is efficient, then edit the sequence together in post. The final result: a polished commercial with consistent character, environment, wardrobe and atmosphere, a supernatural VFX transition, and integrated sound.

> **The professional reality**
>
> Pros go through **hundreds of prompts** before they get the right output. The "one prompt, amazing result in 5 minutes" story is misinformation. The process is iterative: prompt → output → refine prompt → new output → repeat until satisfied. It's identical to LLM prompting — except each iteration costs credits, which is why the discipline in §5 matters.

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8. Key Takeaways

- **1. AI diffusion models are the new cameras.** Pick a few favourites and master them — you don't need to learn every model, just the ones that fit your use case and style.
- **2. Image prompting uses comma-separated keywords.** Think like a creative director: subject, action, environment, atmosphere, camera, lighting. Put the most important element first.
- **3. Video prompting uses natural language.** Full sentences. Use image-to-video (not text-to-video) for professional results; use start and end frames for controlled transitions.
- **4. Always include "ultra-realistic, cinematic style".** Without explicit style instructions, models may output cartoons, 3D renders or random aesthetics.
- **5. Use aggregators.** Krea and Freepik give you dozens of models on a single subscription — no separate accounts everywhere.
- **6. Test cheap, finish expensive.** Validate at 720p/1K and on low-credit models; upgrade to 1080p/4K and premium models only for the final generation.
- **7. Iteration is the professional workflow.** Expect hundreds of prompt iterations, not one-shot perfection. Budget credits accordingly.
- **8. Integrated sound changes everything.** Kling 3.0, Veo 3.1 and Seedance 2.0 generate video with native audio, eliminating the expensive lip-sync step.
- **9. Character consistency requires discipline.** Same reference image in every prompt; clothing specified explicitly and consistently across the scene.
- **10. Never use someone's likeness without consent.** The one hard ethical and legal rule of AI visual content.

9. Tool & Resource Directory

Tool	Use case	Website
Krea	Subscription aggregator for image (and video) generation — Nano Banana, Seedream, Flux, GPT Image and more in one interface	krea.ai
Kling	Video generation: start/end frames, camera presets, native 4K/60fps, integrated sound with multilingual lip-sync	klingai.com
Artificial Analysis	Industry-standard, continuously updated leaderboard for AI image, video, audio and LLM models	artificialanalysis.ai
Gemini (Nano Banana Pro / 2)	Google's top image models — Pro for highest quality, 2 for fast, high-volume generation with a generous free tier	gemini.google.com
Veo 3.1	Google's video model — best-in-class 48kHz synchronized dialogue; available via Gemini and aggregators	deepmind.google/models/veo
Seedream / Seedance	ByteDance's image and video models — Seedream for cheap, high-quality testing; Seedance 2.0 for multi-shot storytelling with audio (via aggregators)	seed.bytedance.com
Runway	The pioneer video platform; Gen-4.5 offers the best creative control surface (motion brushes, scene consistency)	runwayml.com
Hailuo	MiniMax's video model — wide landscape shots and motion physics; free trial available	hailuoai.video
Midjourney	Closed-source image model famous for dreamy, artistic aesthetics	midjourney.com
Flux (Black Forest Labs)	Leading open-weight image family — run locally, fine-tune on custom data	bfl.ai
Freepik	Subscription aggregator with access to many image and video models	freepik.com

Tool	Use case	Website
FAL	Pay-per-use aggregator — cheaper per generation, developer-style interface	fal.ai
Replicate	Pay-per-use aggregator for running many open and closed models	replicate.com
Higgsfield	Video generation platform with free trial — useful for extending free usage while learning	higgsfield.ai
CapCut	Free video editing software — the recommended no-cost alternative to Premiere Pro	capcut.com
Adobe Premiere Pro	Professional video editing for assembling and finishing your shots	adobe.com/products/premiere
Magnific	AI upscaling for increasing image resolution and detail	magnific.ai
Topaz Labs	AI upscaling and enhancement for images and video	topazlabs.com
ElevenLabs	AI audio generation — voiceover, dialogue and music for your edits	elevenlabs.io

⚠ Model names, availability and leaderboard positions change monthly in this space — verify on artificialanalysis.ai before committing to a stack.

10. Your Next Step

> **Become the AI Director**
>
> Don't try to learn every model. Pick **one image tool and one video tool** from the directory above, write a three-shot storyboard for something simple — a product you love, a morning routine, a before/after — and produce it this week using the test-cheap-finish-expensive workflow. Your first hundred prompts are the tuition; the skill compounds from there.

See you in the next session. — Team Outskill